

Practice Paper 30 — Answer Scheme

Paper 2 — Comprehension

Sections B & C

Note to teachers and students

- Marks are awarded for **meaning**, not for exact words. Where a quotation is required, it has been indicated in inverted commas.
- Where the question asks for **own words**, a candidate who lifts directly from the text receives **zero** for that mark unless the lifted phrase is unavoidable.
- For language and tone questions, accept any reasonable alternative that clearly fits the textual evidence.

Section B — Text 3 Answer Scheme [20 marks]

Q1. [2] — “The world had not yet decided what it was”

1 mark for identifying that it is the in-between hour before dawn, when neither night nor day has properly arrived.

1 mark for explaining that the scene is **unformed** / **indistinct** — outlines and colours are not yet clear, so even cloud and stone look the same.

Sample answer: The phrase suggests that it is the strange, half-lit hour before dawn, when the landscape has no firm shape; everything looks blurred and uncertain, as though nature itself had not yet chosen between night and morning.

Q2. [2] — Cold “as though it were paper”

1 mark — The **simile** suggests his jersey was **flimsy** / offered almost no protection, as if it were as thin as paper.

1 mark — It also suggests that the **cold was extreme** / **piercing**, since it could pass through cloth so easily.

Q3. [2] — “Quieter, sterner, and unwilling to flatter me”

1 mark for identifying **personification** — the road is given human qualities such as sternness and unwillingness.

1 mark for explaining the **contrast**: in summer with friends the road had felt sociable and forgiving, but alone before dawn it feels strict, serious and **unimpressed** by him, as though it will not make the climb easy.

Q4. [2] — “A small private music”

1 mark — He has settled into a **steady, calm rhythm**; the once unpleasant mechanical noise has become **pleasing** / **companionable**.

1 mark — The word **private** shows that he is **alone** and that the experience belongs only to him, suggesting a **peaceful, meditative** state of mind.

Q5. [2] — “Politely steps outside”

(a) [1]: It is unusual because **worries and the cold** are abstract or physical conditions, but here they are described as **people with manners** who **quietly leave the room** — i.e. **personification**.

(b) [1]: It suggests the climb has produced **intense focus** in him — his mind has narrowed to the pedals and the road, and external concerns are temporarily blocked out.

Q6. [3] — Climb as a battle (language question)

1 mark for identifying **personification** / hostility of the climb; **1 mark each** for **two** clearly quoted and explained details (max 2).

Accept any two of:

- “the road did what mountain roads do. It got cruel.” — the road is given the human quality of **cruelty**, making it sound like an opponent.
- “the gradient stiffened” — the verb **stiffened** makes the slope feel as if it has **hardened against him** / set itself like a fighter.
- “my lungs... began to argue” — his own body is personified as **resisting him**, as in a quarrel.
- “a small, reasonable voice... cleared its throat and pointed out” — the inner voice is also personified, adding to the sense of multiple opponents arguing against the climb.

Each detail must be **quoted** and **explained**; mere lifting without explanation = ½ mark.

Q7. [2] — “The way a teacher places a problem on a desk”

1 mark — The comparison suggests the voice is **calm, neutral and patient**, not emotional or accusing.

1 mark — Like a teacher, it **sets the question in front of him** and leaves him to **think it through alone**, treating him as capable of working out the right answer for himself.

Q8. [1] — “One more gear left”

1 mark — Beyond the literal gear on the bicycle, it suggests he had **one more reserve of effort / willpower** inside him that he had not realised he possessed; the moment is a small **discovery of his own capacity**. (Also accept: a **metaphor for resilience**.)

Q9. [1] — Physical exhaustion at the top

1 mark — Any **one** of:

- “my legs, surprised, briefly forgot what they had been doing”.
- He freewheeled and “stopped, one foot down, the other still clipped in” (too tired to unclip properly).
- “my heart so loud in my ears that I half expected the dawn to hear it”.

Q10. [2] — “Free only because I had paid it”

1 mark — The **sunrise itself costs nothing** — anyone can see it.

1 mark — But its **beauty and meaning** could only be earned by him because he had **suffered the climb**; the effort was the price that made the reward feel worth so much. (**Accept paraphrases of “effort earns the gift”.**)

Q11. [1] — Tone of the final sentence

1 mark — Any **one** of: **reflective, grateful, nostalgic, thoughtful, tender, wistful**. (Reject: **sad, bitter** — these miss the warmth.)

Section C — Text 4 Answer Scheme [25 marks]

Q12. [2] — “The items vary, but the posture does not”

1 mark — The **type of bad news** changes from item to item — floods, scandals, wars and so on are all different.

1 mark — But the **physical and mental position** of the doomscroller stays the same — slumped on the sofa or in bed, thumb moving downwards, unable to stop.

Q13. [2] — Why bad news is “sticky”

1 mark — The human brain evolved to **pay more attention to threats than to ordinary good news**.

1 mark — Because noticing a danger once **helped early humans survive**, the brain is wired to **hold on to / fix on** negative information more readily than positive information.

Q14. [2] — Effect of “even when readers reported afterwards that they had not enjoyed reading them”

1 mark — It shows that the behaviour is **involuntary / compulsive** — readers click on bad news **against their own wishes**.

1 mark — It strengthens the writer’s argument that doomscrolling is **not a conscious choice or a moral failure** but is driven by the brain’s automatic wiring.

Q15. [2] — “Has no opinion about your well-being”

1 mark — The **algorithm does not care** whether the content is good or bad for the user.

1 mark — Its only goal is to **keep the user watching as long as possible**; it is **indifferent** to the user’s mental health, since it is judged only by attention captured.

Reject lifts of “predict what will keep your eyes on the screen” without rewording.

Q16. [2] — “A marriage of an ancient instinct and an industrial-grade delivery system”

1 mark — **Ancient instinct** refers to the human brain’s **evolved bias** towards threats — a deep, biological feature.

1 mark — **Industrial-grade delivery system** suggests modern technology is **powerful, mass-produced and relentless**; the **metaphor of marriage** shows the two are tightly joined and reinforce each other, making the loop hard to escape.

Q17. [2] — “Permanently bracing for the next bad thing”

1 mark — **Bracing** suggests **physical tensing** / readiness for a blow, so they are mentally tense at all times.

1 mark — **Permanently** shows that this anxiety is **constant and unresolved** — they cannot relax even when nothing bad is happening in their own lives.

Q18. [2] — Why “ambient dread” among teenagers is worrying

1 mark — It is a **low-grade, constant worry** that is **not attached to any real event** in the teenager’s own life.

1 mark — Because the dread has no specific cause, it **cannot be solved or talked through**, and young people may carry this background anxiety into adulthood as a permanent state.

Q19. [2] — Damage to concentration

1 mark each for any two of:

- Readers can no longer “sit with a single paragraph of a book” after consuming many short shocks.
- The mind “grows restless when offered anything slower” / has been trained to expect fresh shocks.
- Young readers, when given a long article, reach reflexively for a thumb-flick that “is no longer there”.
- Teachers, librarians and editors all report the same complaint.

Q20. [1] — Tone of “at best, half-hearted”

1 mark — Any **one of: critical, disapproving, sceptical, dryly disappointed**. (Reject: **furious, neutral**.)

Q21. [2] — Effect of the closing line

1 mark — The word **small** makes the act sound **modest and achievable**, while **repeated** shows that it is a **daily discipline** rather than a one-off fix — this is **realistic** rather than dramatic.

1 mark — **Honesty of admitting** puts the **responsibility on the reader**, ending the article on a quiet, **personal** note that contrasts with the loudness of the scroll itself.

Q22. Summary [13 marks total: 6 content + 7 style]

Content points (½ mark each, max 6 marks). Eight available content points; candidates should aim for all 8.

Why doomscrolling is harmful (Paragraphs 4–5):

1. Heavy scrollers are **more anxious and sleep-deprived** than others.
2. They feel **constantly braced for bad news** even when their own lives are stable.
3. Teenagers show a rise in **ambient / free-floating dread** not linked to any real event.
4. It causes a **slow erosion of concentration** / inability to sit with longer reading.
5. The mind is **trained to expect fresh shocks** and grows **restless** with slower material.

What individuals can practically do (Paragraph 7):

6. **Delay**: keep the phone out of the bedroom / out of the first and last hour of the day.
7. **Replacement**: substitute slower activities such as a book, walk or crossword.
8. **Limits**: schedule short, finite news blocks from a few trusted sources, rather than endless scrolling.

Sample full-marks summary (78 words):

Doomscrolling is harmful because heavy users grow anxious, sleep-poorly, and feel permanently tense even when their lives are calm, while teenagers develop a vague dread unattached to real events. It also slowly erodes concentration, leaving the mind restless and unable to settle on longer reading. Individuals can fight back by keeping phones out of the bedroom and the day’s edges, replacing the scroll with a book, walk or puzzle, and confining news to brief, scheduled checks.

Length count: 78 words from “Doomscrolling” onwards.

— END OF ANSWER SCHEME —